

toured as a pianist and in 1857–1860 held a part-time post as conductor of the choral society of the princely court at Detmold, but he was always able to devote much of his time to composing. In 1862, he visited Vienna for the first time and he settled there the following year when he was made director of the Singakademie, a renowned choral society; later he was director of another of the city's distinguished musical organizations, the Gesellschaft der Musikfreunde (Society of Friends of Music).

Public success

In 1865, Brahms's mother died, and he expressed his grief in his German Requiem, which he had begun earlier as a tribute to Schumann. It was first performed in 1868 and established Brahms in the front rank of living composers. He also achieved success with works in a lighter vein, notably his Hungarian Dances for piano duet (1869). At a time when a piano was an essential feature in middle-class homes, this kind of music was hugely popular for domestic performance and in money-making terms the Dances were almost the equivalent of a hit record today.

**“It is as though he [Brahms] has been sent
by God himself !”**

CLARA SCHUMANN, ON BRAHMS PLAYING HIS
OWN WORK